EAC GUIDELINES 9

ASSESSING ARCHAEOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE: KEY CONCEPTS

Prepared by the 'Articulating the Significance of Archaeological Sites' Working Group

European Archaeological Council

INTRODUCTION

Evaluating the significance of archaeological sites and remains is a vital aspect of the archaeological process that underpins the management of the historic environment across Europe. State heritage managers and heritage practitioners are challenged to assess the significance of archaeological sites and remains and most use the results of assessment processes in their daily work. And yet evaluating and articulating the significance of archaeology presents a core philosophical question at the heart of heritage management. Can the notion of the intrinsic value of heritage be upheld? In assessing the significance of archaeological heritage, the task is to ensure that all stakeholders clearly understand how the evaluation has been formulated especially in the context of articulating 'community value and amenity'[1]. Heritage significance is articulated in different ways for different stakeholders and is likely to be articulated differently by country and through time. The complexity of defining significance, which is inherently philosophical, shaped by cultural narratives and evolving societal values, implies reflective heritage management practices.

One can also ask whether it is possible to create generalised guidance on this topic as this will depend on the purpose the assessment of significance is due to serve. At the outset of this project the EAC Working Group intended to set out a "best practice" guideline of evaluating significance. But it quickly became clear that this was not a practical way to proceed; while principles on which significance assessment rests can be defined, it is simply impossible to define a single, multinational "best practice" guidance in this field. Those who are charged with the assessment of archaeological heritage significance are first and foremost heritage managers who prepare and use state inventories of heritage. The secondary users are practitioners that must articulate the significance of archaeological heritage to a range of public audiences, especially those involved in land use and development planning and development control. Diverse approaches and different systems exist in different countries. The material collected by the Working Group reveals the wide range of methodological diversity in different European countries. Nonetheless, there are common baselines and similarities.

The process led to the idea that this publication could perhaps serve as a bank of ideas or provide examples of best practice. Neither were considered ambitious enough in themselves. But with further thought, a combination of both was considered a practical alternative. The Working Group can indeed present an inspiring bank of ideas – presenting how the evaluation of archaeological sites and assessment of their significance is conducted in different parts of Europe, and instead of talking of "best practice", we talk about "good practice". In all the diversity of methods, there are common syntax principles and objectives.

To support this combined objective, the Working Group has produced two published volumes. This short document provides an overview of **key concepts** for consideration when undertaking the process of evaluating or articulating archaeological significance. Some of the key points are

[1]Historic and Archaeological Heritage and Miscellaneous Provisions Act 2023. (Ireland) No. 26, 2023. Available https://www.irishstatutebook.ie/eli/2023/act/26/

quite philosophical, but the observations that follow each point are meant to give references to practical cases and examples that are written about in more depth in the longer document. The observation text also reflects on many issues that the working group dealt with in its meetings. The accompanying longer text (EAC11) explores in more detail the philosophical questions that heritage managers face when articulating the significance of archaeological heritage and gives an overview of the methods, systems and approaches used for evaluating significance in different countries of Europe, complemented and supported by individual case studies. The purpose of these guidelines is thus not to provide a manual on how to define significance but to provide principles and a toolkit of varied approaches that may be drawn upon to assist in the assessment of significance, together with key considerations when articulating the significance of heritage assets in various contexts.

This publication forms one of several interlinked resources developed to provide EAC members with tools to help them manage their archaeological heritage:

The Benefits of Development-Led Archaeology (EAC Guidelines 4 and EAC Guidelines 5)
Developing National Research Frameworks (EAC Guidelines 7 and EAC Guidelines 8)

Articulating the Significance of Archaeological Sites (EAC Guidelines 11)

This document and the accompanying longer text has been developed by the Working Group on Articulating the Significance of Archaeological Sites of the European Archaeological Council.

THE IMPORTANCE AND ROLE OF SIGNIFICANCE IN HERITAGE MANAGEMENT

The purpose of assessing the significance of archaeological heritage is to inform decision-making about its management at a variety of levels including state level. It includes the identification of the elements and attributes that may require protection and addressing why and how these can be managed in the future as a resource of value. The assessment of significance guides conservation efforts, informs policy development, and enhances public engagement by articulating the value of heritage assets. It also helps to inform decisions about the future security of heritage assets that may be subject to development or other pressures. It plays a critical role in balancing heritage conservation with these pressures. This balance requires transparent, evidence-based decision-making processes. Statements of significance describe the different meanings of a place and articulate its socio-cultural importance, at the same time as identifying the need for protection and support to safeguard the future of the asset including considerations of other appropriate measures to unlock the public benefit inherent in the resource.

Research and excavation of archaeological sites provides new knowledge and often contributes to an understanding the past of a place, its cultural context and, by association, its significance. Public dissemination of excavation activities and their results add to public awareness of a site's history and its importance. Archaeological excavation is a form of study and revelation of the past that involves processes of physical removal. Excavated archaeology sites acquire significance through their contribution to local knowledge of the past and to national research and may exist as records on historic maps. Heritage managers often need to deal with the challenge of articulating value in the context of land-use change and development pressure. Decisions need to be made based on the significance of a site. Preservation in situ and design alteration may be advised in some circumstances. Where a site must be removed, archaeological excavation 'preservation by record' is the appropriate option so that the resource is not lost. Different countries have different approaches to this requirement.

For managers of the archaeological heritage, significance refers to the meaning of the resource in its context, and to its relative values in comparison to other resources. These meanings evolve over time, influenced by new research, societal changes, and evolving cultural values. This dynamic nature requires periodic reassessment to reflect current understanding and community perspectives.

HOW IS SIGNIFICANCE DEFINED?

Assessment of significance can be based on different criteria but in general the following values and criteria are used in most countries in one way or another:

VALUES: THE INHERENT QUALITIES OR MEANINGS ATTRIBUTED TO A HERITAGE ASSET.

Common types of values include:

- Archaeological/ historical/ cultural significance: Importance due to association with past events, people, or periods.
- Aesthetic value: Visual, sensory, or artistic qualities that inspire or engage.
- Research/ scientific value: A source of new knowledge.
- Social/ community value: Importance to a community's identity, traditions, or practices.
- Spiritual value: Connection to religious, spiritual, or sacred traditions.
- Symbolic value: Representation of ideas, principles, or cultural identity.
- Experience: Qualities of authenticity, sense of place and historical meaning.

CRITERIA: THE STANDARDS USED TO EVALUATE THE PRESENCE AND DEGREE OF EACH VALUE.

- Preservation status, integrity/ authenticity (quality of the archaeological remains).
- Rarity on regional/ national level.
- Landscape/ context value (the relationship of the asset to its surroundings, landscape, or broader historical and cultural context).
- Physical presence, visibility.
- Accessibility.

WHAT IS CHANGING ABOUT HOW WE DEFINE SIGNIFICANCE?

- External parameters (eg. legislative change).
- Who is involved in the process.
- Who the process benefits, and how.

Articulating the significance of archaeological heritage is a critical task for heritage managers and for validating the legal protection of archaeological sites. It is important therefore that the evaluation of sites, based on their significance, is transparent and well-documented.To maintain credibility and trust it must be understandable for everyone, including all stakeholders and those involved in the processes of land use and development planning, as well as the general public. The system used must be sensible, robust and agreed upon. It is equally important that heritage managers can demonstrate that decisions are based on a sound and systematic methodology rather than simply being dependent on subjective judgement or opinion. Heritage management advice and decisions often have to compete with other interests and values. Heritage managers must therefore be capable of explaining why cultural heritage has value and advocating for its scientific, social amenity, economic and other benefits. This ensures that decisions are defensible, reproducible, and comprehensible to all stakeholders involved. Heritage managers define significance for a variety of reasons, such as:

- Protecting (listing/ scheduling) sites.
- Preserving sites in situ (for example in the context of spatial planning developments).
- Active conservation management.
- Specifying the extent of archaeological intervention, e.g. evaluation, to be carried out (primarily in development-led archaeology).
- Advocacy for preservation, or where this is not possible, defining and overseeing appropriate mitigation measures.
- Research designs for heritage or development projects, e.g. research, restoration, reconstruction or presentation.
- Elaborating evidence-based methodology.

DEFINING THE LEGISLATIVE CONTEXT FOR THE ROLE OF SIGNIFICANCE

The UNESCO Convention for the Protection of the World Cultural and Natural Heritage (1972) deployed the concept of 'outstanding universal value' (OUV) as a means of identifying and selecting the most significant natural and cultural heritage sites at a global level. In 1979 the Australia ICOMOS Burra Charter (further developed and revised in 2013) adopted a much more directly values-led approach to conservation and heritage management and the Valletta Convention for the protection, conservation, and management of the archaeological heritage (1992) reflected this approach[2]. Today, most European states have developed – to a greater or lesser extent – a functioning legal system grounded on the provisions of the Valletta Convention. EAC11 describes the systems of five European countries regarding the preservation of archaeological remains and factors that are relied upon when assessing the significance of sites.

Since 1992, heritage management practice has continued to evolve, building a more flexible, inclusive, dynamic, and integrative approach which addresses the whole of the historic environment (archaeology, buildings, and landscapes) as a single entity. In 1996, the Helsinki Declaration[3] marked a significant shift away from a conservation-oriented scientific and technological approach to one that explored ways in which culture and heritage could support social progress and the fundamental values of European unification[4]. The Council of Europe's Declaration on Cultural Diversity (2000) stimulated consideration of the relationship between citizenship, cultural identity, human rights, and core values.

These approaches are embodied in the European Convention on the Value of Cultural Heritage for Society (Faro Convention, 2005). The Faro Convention puts people and human values at the centre of an enlarged and cross-disciplinary concept of cultural heritage. It presents heritage as a resource and amenity for human development, the enhancement of cultural diversity, and the promotion of intercultural dialogue. The principle of access to cultural heritage as a fundamental human right then provides a link between heritage practice and social cohesion (as a form of public benefit). The Faro Convention also specifically supports public participation in cultural heritage activities and decision-making and provides for the development of legal, financial, and professional frameworks for joint actions by public authorities, experts, owners, investors, businesses, non-governmental organizations and civil society and for voluntary initiatives which complement the role of public authorities (Article 12).

[2]ICOMOS (ed), The Burra Charter: the Australia ICOMOS Charter for Places of Cultural Significance, Australia 2013.
[3]Council of Europe (ed), European Cultural Heritage (Volume 1) Intergovernmental co-operation: collected texts, Strasbourg 2002, 43–49.
[4]*Daniel Thérond*, Benefits and innovations of the Council of Europe Framework Convention on the Value of Cultural Heritage for Society. In: Council of Europe 2009. Heritage and Beyond, Strasbourg 2009, 9–12.

KEY CONSIDERATIONS WHEN DEFINING SIGNIFICANCE

THERE IS NO UNIVERSAL AND ACCEPTED DEFINITION OF SIGNIFICANCE

Significance varies and changes through time – it cannot be absolute.

The definition of significance ascribes a value on a scale of relative values – it is neither positive nor negative. Significance is a 'point in time' judgement that helps to support the need for further action. A fundamental question for heritage management is whether or not the value of heritage assets is intrinsic. It can also be understood to be subject to change in line with changing attitudes in society and culture. The value and significance of monuments and archaeological remains and the priorities for heritage management have developed over time (EAC11). They are constantly informed by research that defines and refines understandings of the key elements of material culture. Most countries have legislation on the protection of cultural heritage and an administration system that ensures the provisions of the legislation and its goals in a national context. Its importance can be considered a core value for social and cultural identity, amenity and well-being that is widely accepted in society, although aspects may change as society develops and changes. Heritage management must therefore be resilient while catering for adaptation to change.

UNDERSTANDING OF SIGNFICANCE IS CONSTANTLY EVOLVING AND SHIFTING

Today there is an increasingly plural understanding of significance that reflects a growing awareness of the multiplicity and shifting nature of heritage values globally.

In an EAC survey in 2019, all countries that responded agreed that significance is not a constant in cultural heritage but changes through time (EAC11). In some cases, change can be sensitive: for example, where monuments and history have been used politically, either positively or negatively. Changes can also be caused by alterations in development priorities and attitudes in development control policy towards archaeology and heritage. The focus of archaeological heritage management interest may also extend, for example increased interest in 20th-century remains or contemporary archaeology. These sites often lie outside the existing legal framework and they include the cultural landscapes surrounding sites and their socio-economic systems that are rarely inventoried and protected (EAC11: Pitschenbergalm, Austria), while it is accepted that aspects of the archaeological and cultural heritage cannot be understood without reference to the ambient or surrounding landscape (EAC11: Thjorsardalur, Iceland; Kurese, Pärnu County, Estonia; burial landscapes, the Netherlands). A growing awareness of submerged landscapes has resulted in a greater emphasis on maritime archaeology in recent years (EAC11: Vrouw Maria, Finland). It should also be kept in mind that those professionally charged with responsibility for assessing the significance of sites are making judgement within their own time – sharing the world views and knowledge and priorities of their contemporaries. When assessing cultural heritage true objectivity is not possible.

ASSIGNING SIGNIFICANCE IS ABOUT NEGOTIATING VALUES

Perception of significance may vary among different groups, so it is always subjective and needs to be understood in relation to the context, knowledge, and cultural (in its broadest sense) frameworks of those who ascribe it.

Archaeological heritage is related to very long processes in place and time. The significance of heritage assets therefore depends on the multiplicity of contexts from which it derives and is percieved and used. Significance of specific assets can embody different, and even conflicting values. All values are attributed by people and through human appreciation. Issues regarding the "ownership" of remains/ monuments, identity and political interests are extremely complex and are influenced by who controls the narrative and how sites have different value for different groups. The Faro Convention recognizes these issues: that perspectives and stories related to place can vary widely. In this way, recent remains that are close to living memory can have differing or contested meanings and may elicit strong impacts on people's feelings; conversely significance can increase with antiquity and rarity. Archaeological sites are often meaningful, as sacred or holy places, or places that are symbols of power and can even be regarded as a legal basis for demands on property or land (EAC11: Raasepori, The Castle of Raseborg, Finland). With increased migration within and into Europe in recent decades, the question of inclusion of different perspectives has never been more important.

SIGNIFICANCE IS AMBIGUOUS

In the context of archaeological heritage management, significance is a dynamic concept that is determined on the basis of a range of assessments and different interpretations.

Signficance is an inherently abstract concept, representing values that are intangible, subjective, and context-dependent. In archaeological heritage management, significance is defined and understood in different ways and in different circumstances, including different regions and states. It is therefore impossible to define a single way to operationalise the evaluation of significance. Significance is not a readily quantifiable value but a value that is attributed as an outcome of societal processes, cultural and historical interpretations, which can vary across time and communities. In recent decades, the perceived significance of archaeological heritage has been influenced by shifting perspectives and broader societal values beyond traditional historic, artistic, aesthetic, scientific heritage value judgements, to embrace broader values linked to social amenity, sense of place and social identity. This ambiguity is further amplified by the fragmentary nature of archaeological sites, where partial evidence and gaps in understanding make it difficult to define significance with certainty (EAC11: The Dolmen Field, Israel).

SIGNIFICANCE INCLUDES INTRINSIC VALUES WHICH REQUIRE CONTEXTUALISING

Contextualizing intrinsic values requires access to appropriate levels of research and synthesis.

Despite the absence of a universal model, most significance assessments rely on approaches that focus on identifying the temporal, regional, and thematic contexts necessary to understand the broader meaning of heritage sites. Traditionally, technically evaluated intrinsic values (eg. *Authenticiy, Integrity, Rarity, Condition/ state of preservation, Fragility/ vulnerability*) of an asset are assessed in comparison to other heritage assets of the same *Period, Type, Category,* and past and current cultural context. Different regions, communities, and time periods may emphasize certain values over others, reflecting the dynamic nature of heritage and the diverse ways in which significance is interpreted globally. This diversity requires expertise from various domains and sophisticated comparative analysis as part of the assessment, underpinned by an appropriate understanding of the wider resource in local, regional, national, and international contexts. The criteria employed in assessing significance require a degree of adaptability to local and national circumstances and must have the capacity to evolve to accommodate changing legal, professional and social perceptions and interpretations of heritage.

SIGNIFICANCE IS RELATIVE TO MULTIPLE VALUES AND DEPENDENT ON MULTIPLE CONTEXTS

Perceptions of significance are often coloured by a single context and by the intellectual framework within which the assessor makes the determination, but it is important to recognize that significance embraces multiple values and is dependent on multiple contexts.

Evaluation of significance should, where possible, take into account a wide range of different values including ambient social, community and multiple stakeholder values. Secure judgements of significance require public engagement as well as technical/ academic assessment. Identifying why and how heritage assets can be protected and managed in the future requires consideration of the competing social, developmental and/or political priorities may alter the context in which the significance of archaeological heritage is perceived. The negative impacts of climate change, extreme weather events, environmental degradation, social mobility, political priorities and conflict all affect the context in which archaeological heritage management functions. The need to articulate and advocate for the significance of archaeological monuments, sites and urban areas becomes more challenging in these situations. The weight of differing interests can also shift dramatically over a short time. The inherent meaning and values of heritage sites do not change, but the priorities for protection and management do. Assessment methods must adapt, incorporating risk analysis and crisis response strategies to ensure heritage management remains responsive to real-world challenges while preserving core values and significance. All these situations call for secure management strategies and require appropriate knowledge, coupled with negotiation and arbitration skills to find appropriate solutions and to reconcile differing interests and perspectives (EAC11: Gdańsk, Poland).

APPROACHES TO THE ASSESSMENT OF SIGNIFICANCE SHOULD BE OPEN AND QUESTIONING

Assessment of significance is not a technical procedure but a critical approach.

In the context of archaeological heritage management, the assessment of significance cannot be a technical operational procedure linked to a definitive formulation or model that grades or scores the significance of different assets. Rather it is a critical approach that is part of an ongoing reflective process of negotiating a range of different societal and educational values applied at a single point in time. Any guidance on the evaluation of significance should reflect the diversity of international approaches to assessing and understanding significance and take into account the wide range of intrinsic and extrinsic values that can combine within a particular context or heritage asset.

The technical approach aims for objectivity and transparency – using score systems, for consistency and a clear matrix of arguments that use methods for decision-making that are widely agreed on. This provides clear and understandable arguments especially when dealing with different stakeholders, but the question rises, to what extent it is possible to depend on such score systems? In practice heritage managers work within national legal frameworks that require an evaluation process that is quite technical. As for example, in some countries, archaeological remains fall under automatic age protection and score points just for that. In some cases, particular values such as rarity of remains, can be evaluated with scores. EAC11 contains examples of a number of evaluation systems and projects in use in different countries, showing a variety of qualitative methods, standardized score lists and research attempts (e.g. EAC11: Szentendre Island, Hungary). So, in practice, heritage managers use both approaches, technical within the legal framework and beyond that, using particular values, to keep consistency. But a more critical approach takes over when it becomes more complicated, as for example when looking at landscapes and the context of things (EAC11: Kampinos, Poland). Recent decades have seen a shift from the technical to the critical approach, and it is worth bearing in mind that although accountability and transparency are the goal at any given point in time, in the end it is "expert assessment" rather than an objective formula. In addition, legal framework changes and even values like rarity could change with new discoveries.

ASSESSMENT OF SIGNIFICANCE SHOULD INCLUDE AN UNDERSTANDING OF THE RELEVANT INTANGIBLE VALUES

Defining wider aspects of significance requires heritage managers to draw on local priorities, traditions, skills, knowledge, and experience of place to supplement technical understandings of intrinsic heritage values.

Despite the greater attention paid to the articulation of the importance of social and societal values of heritage in recent instruments and policy documents, existing heritage management systems still often fail to integrate societal values, practices, traditions, and local knowledge. The values that people assign to 'their' heritage require important consideration. While there is evidence that public awareness and (meaningful) interest in protecting the heritage remains consistently at a fairly low level for many communities, with help it can become an important aspect of sense of place, community identity, and cohesion[5]. The connection between the *material culture* and the *living culture* has an important impact on the evaluation of significance (EAC11: Dumbarton Rock, Scotland). If the people who make the living culture stop using a place or monument, in what way would the significance of it change? Old buildings, not to mention archaeological sites, have usually been re-used in some way, adding new stories to them. But people's memories and connection to a place through intangible traditions is something that needs to be considered when evaluating significance.

[5]eg. In Ireland: the Adopt a Monument scheme in Ireland https://www.heritagecouncil.ie/projects/aam and Community Archaeology https://www.fingal.ie/community-and-archaeology

ASSESSMENT OF SIGNIFICANCE REQUIRES ACTIVE PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT TO ENSURE DELIVERY OF PUBLIC BENEFIT

Assessment of significance needs wide participation by all stakeholders including local communities (and where applicable indigenous people).

The challenge for heritage professionals today is to explore how heritage management can be combined with effective community and public engagement, in a new matrix that will deliver increased public benefit at the same time as supporting integrated value-led conservation. This means integrating the purely technical aspects of heritage management and conservation with a direct, meaningful, two-way engagement between heritage professionals and public communities so that public value is firmly grounded in a realistic understanding of public attitudes and needs (EAC5). A more rounded understanding of all aspects of significance lies at the heart of this process together with an understanding of other aspects of legal landscape protection and designation, such as biodiversity and nature restoration and cross-cutting issues such as climate action and adaptation.

The evaluation of significance is usually undertaken in line with the legal framework of the country concerned. Often it is carried out in connection with land use planning work (EAC11: The Dolmen Field, Israel; Gdańsk, Poland; Barronstrand Street, Ireland) or in connection with the assessment of the environmental and heritage impact of development projects (EAC11: Hveravellir, Iceland). In both cases, these formal procedures seek to secure the involvement of the public in decision-making. Across Europe it is usual that regions and municipalities have the responsibility to advertise and ensure that public consultation takes place. In these circumstances, archaeological, historical and land surveys are undertaken for the purposes of detailed evaluation and impact assessment. The range of development mitigation measures (including everything from re-design and design amelioration to archaeological excavation) will include consideration of the site's potential as public amenity, either as part of the development, or located on its periphery. By purposefully including archaeological sites in local land use planning, be it archaeological parks, in-situ preservation or "transformation of sites" (EAC11: Leithon, the Netherlands), it adds to the value or significance of the site and deepens people's sense for the historic depth of their surroundings.

Decision-making regarding the protection of sites is a matter for the law, and the responsibility rests with heritage managers to advocate for the archaeological heritage concerned. This includes cases where there are no visible remains and digital presentation and remote sensing survey results are required (EAC11: Carnuntum, Austria; Mapping of archaeology-sensitive areas for municipalities comprehensive plans, Estonia). The significance of the site can also be simply laid out in the context of financial risk for proposed development. However, while it remains the responsibility of the specialists to explain and articulate the significance of each site in connection with change management, at the same time, decision making and heritage preservation work benefits from, and its impact is increased by, constructive dialogue and cooperation with the public and other stakeholders (EAC11: Füzesgyarmat – Bárdos-halom, Hungary and Kampinos, Poland).

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